RESEARCH PROJECT – STRUCTURED WORK PLAN

Dear Students,

You have already been allotted your research topics. you are expected to move from learning research concepts to developing a research study.

All teams must follow the structure given below.

STAGE 1 -UNDERSTAND YOUR RESEARCH TOPIC

1. Research Topic

Write your allotted research topic exactly as finalized.

2. Background of the Study

Briefly explain:

- What is the topic about?
- Why is it important?
- What is happening in the business/industry?
- Why is this topic worth studying?

Limit: 150–200 words.

STAGE 2 -IDENTIFY THE RESEARCH PROBLEM

Do not directly start with a questionnaire.

First understand the problem behind your topic.

3. Management Problem

What business problem or opportunity requires investigation?

Example:

Management Problem:
A company is experiencing declining customer retention.

4. Research Problem

Convert the management problem into a researchable problem.

Example:

Research Problem:
What factors influence customer retention among users of the company's services?

5. Research Questions

Frame 3–5 questions.

For example:

- Does service quality influence customer retention?
- Does price perception influence customer retention?
- Does customer satisfaction influence customer retention?

STAGE 3 -REVIEW OF LITERATURE

This is one of the most important stages.

6. Collect Research Articles

Use minimum 10 and maximum 15 relevant research articles.

Articles should preferably be:

- Peer-reviewed research papers
- Relevant to your topic
- Recent where possible
- From credible journals/databases

Avoid depending mainly on:

- Random websites
- Blogs
- Wikipedia
- Newspaper articles

STAGE 4 -ARTICLE-WISE REVIEW

For every article, identify:

No.	Author & Year	Objective	Variables	Method	Key Finding
1					
2					
3					
...					
10–15					

For every article, identify:

1. What was studied?
2. Why was it studied?
3. What variables were used?
4. How was the study conducted?
5. What did the researchers find?

Do not simply copy the abstract.

Read -Understand -Extract -Summarize.

STAGE 5 -IDENTIFY VARIABLES

After reviewing all 10–15 articles, prepare a consolidated variable list.

Example:

Variable	Number of Studies Using It	Supporting Articles
Price	8	Author 1, 3, 5...
Service Quality	7	Author 2, 4, 6...
Brand Image	5	Author 1, 7...
Trust	4	Author 3, 8...

This will help you understand which variables are commonly studied.

STAGE 6 -CLASSIFY VARIABLES

Identify:

Independent Variables (IV)

Variables that are expected to influence another variable.

Dependent Variable (DV)

The main outcome you want to explain or predict.

Example:

Price
Service Quality
Brand Image → Customer Purchase Decision

Here:

- Price = IV
- Service Quality = IV
- Brand Image = IV
- Purchase Decision = DV

STAGE 7 -IDENTIFY THE RESEARCH GAP

This is not simply:

“Very few studies have been conducted.”

You must identify what exactly is missing.

Look for gaps such as:

Context Gap

Previous studies were conducted in another city/country/industry.

Population Gap

Previous studies examined one group but not your target population.

Variable Gap

Important variable has not been sufficiently examined.

Methodological Gap

Previous studies used one method, but another method may provide additional insight.

Time Gap

Earlier studies were conducted in a different period/context.

Contradictory Findings

Different studies produced different results.

STAGE 8 -PROPOSE YOUR RESEARCH GAP

Write 3–5 clear points.

Example:

Previous studies have examined the influence of price and service quality on customer satisfaction. However, limited research has examined the role of digital reviews among young consumers in Hyderabad.

Then explain:

Therefore, the present study proposes to examine _____.

STAGE 9 -FINALIZE YOUR VARIABLES

Now decide which variables will be included in your study.

Important:

Do not add variables simply because they sound interesting.

Every variable should have a reason:

Literature support OR clearly justified research gap.

For every proposed variable, provide at least one supporting reference wherever possible.

Prepare:

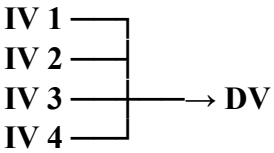
Variable	Source/Reference	Reason for Inclusion

IV 1		
IV 2		
IV 3		
IV 4		
DV		

STAGE 10 -CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Develop a simple conceptual framework showing the expected relationship between variables.

Example:



Clearly identify:

- Independent Variables
- Dependent Variable

If you propose a mediator/moderator, clearly justify it with literature.

STAGE 11 -RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

Your objectives must come from your variables and research problem.

For example:

General Objective

To examine the factors influencing consumer purchase decisions.

Specific Objectives

1. To examine the influence of price on purchase decisions.
2. To assess the influence of service quality on purchase decisions.
3. To examine the influence of brand image on purchase decisions.
4. To determine the most influential factor affecting purchase decisions.

STAGE 12 -HYPOTHESES

Convert the expected relationships into testable hypotheses.

Example:

H1: Price significantly influences consumer purchase decisions.

H2: Service quality significantly influences consumer purchase decisions.

H3: Brand image significantly influences consumer purchase decisions.

Do not formulate hypotheses merely because you have variables.

There must be a **logical relationship between the variables**, preferably supported by literature.

STAGE 13 -RESEARCH DESIGN

Decide which research design is appropriate.

Exploratory

When you need to understand an unclear problem.

Descriptive

When you want to measure and describe characteristics, opinions or behavior.

Causal

When you want to test cause-and-effect relationships, typically through an appropriate experimental design.

IMPORTANT

Do not simply write:

"The study uses exploratory, descriptive and causal research."

Explain **why** a particular design is appropriate.

STAGE 14 -RESEARCH METHOD

Decide whether your study is:

Qualitative

- Interviews
- Focus groups
- Observation

Quantitative

- Survey
- Structured questionnaire
- Numerical data
- Statistical analysis

If you use a mixed-method approach, clearly explain why both are required.

STAGE 15 -MEASUREMENT OF VARIABLES

For every variable, identify:

1. Variable
2. Dimensions
3. Measurement items
4. Scale
5. Source of measurement items

Example:

Variable: Customer Satisfaction

Possible dimensions/items:

- Satisfaction with product quality
- Satisfaction with price
- Satisfaction with service
- Overall satisfaction

Use established/adapted measurement items from relevant literature wherever possible.

STAGE 16 -QUESTIONNAIRE DESIGN

Prepare your questionnaire in sections.

Section A -Screening Questions

Example:

Have you purchased this product/service during the last six months?

Yes / No

Section B -Variable Measurement

Use appropriate items for each variable.

Section C -Demographic/Profile Questions

Examples:

- Age
- Gender
- Education

- Income
- Occupation

Use only demographic variables relevant to your study.

STAGE 17 -PILOT TESTING

Before collecting final data:

Test your questionnaire with a small group of respondents.

Check:

- Is any question confusing?
- Are any questions repetitive?
- Are response options adequate?
- Is the questionnaire too long?
- Do respondents understand the statements?

Make necessary corrections before final data collection.

STAGE 18 -POPULATION & SAMPLING

Clearly identify:

Population

Who do you want to study?

Sampling Frame

What actual list/source can you use to identify/select members of the population?

Sample Size

How many respondents will you study?

Sampling Technique

Choose an appropriate technique.

Probability Sampling

- Simple Random
- Systematic
- Stratified
- Cluster

Non-Probability Sampling

- Convenience
- Purposive
- Quota
- Snowball

IMPORTANT

You must justify your sampling technique.

Do not select “convenience sampling” simply because it is easy.

STAGE 19 -DATA COLLECTION

Specify:

- Where will data be collected?
- Who will collect it?
- How will respondents be approached?
- Online or offline?
- What is the proposed data collection period?

STAGE 20 -DATA ANALYSIS PLAN

Before collecting data, decide what analysis is appropriate.

Descriptive Analysis

- Frequency
- Percentage
- Mean
- Standard deviation
- Charts/graphs

Inferential Analysis

Depending on your research objectives and data:

- t-test
- ANOVA
- Chi-square
- Correlation
- Regression

- Other appropriate tests

IMPORTANT

Do not choose statistical tests simply because they are available in SPSS.

The research question, variable type, measurement level, design and assumptions should guide the choice of analysis.

STAGE 21 -FINAL RESEARCH MODEL

Every team should finally be able to show:

Research Problem

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Research Objectives

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Literature Review

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Research Gap

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Variables

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Conceptual Framework

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Hypotheses

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Research Design

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Questionnaire / Data Collection Tool

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Population & Sampling

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Data Collection

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Data Analysis

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Findings

↓

Conclusion & Recommendations

TEAM PRESENTATION

Each team will prepare a PPT containing:

Slide 1

Research Title & Team Members

Slide 2

Background of the Study

Slide 3

Management Problem

Slide 4

Research Problem

Slide 5

Research Questions & Objectives

Slides 6–10

Review of Literature

Slide 11

Consolidated Variables from Literature

Slide 12

Independent & Dependent Variables

Slide 13

Research Gap

Slide 14

Proposed Variables & Justification

Slide 15

Conceptual Framework

Slide 16

Hypotheses

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Slide 17

Proposed Research Design & Methodology

Slide 18

Sampling Plan

Slide 19

Proposed Questionnaire Structure

Slide 20

References

IMPORTANT RULES

DO:

- Read the articles carefully.
- Cite every source properly.
- Use variables supported by literature.
- Explain your research gap.
- Justify methodological choices.
- Use citation management software such as Zotero/Mendeley.
- Maintain proper academic referencing.

DON'T:

- Copy-paste literature.
- Invent a research gap.
- Add random variables.
- Create hypotheses without logical relationships.
- Select a sample size without justification.
- Copy questionnaire items without checking their source.
- Claim that a variable is “new” simply because your team has not seen it before.

Note: Before moving to questionnaire preparation**,** every team must be able to answer these 7 questions:

1. What is our research problem?
2. What exactly are we trying to find out?
3. What have previous researchers found?
4. What is missing in existing research?

5. What variables are we going to study?
6. Why have we selected these variables?
7. How are we going to measure and study them?

If you cannot answer these seven questions clearly, do not start collecting data yet.

Dr RK